

Homework Format Policy/Guidelines/Suggestions
Physics Faculty draft spring 2015

Goals: These policies exist to reinforce quality homework preparation styles. This allows **students** to produce documents that effectively and responsibly communicate information. You should keep in mind the philosophy that another student should be able to pick up your assignment and present your work immediately given only your homework solution. Additional details may make your homework solutions easier to grade.

1. Use standard sized clean paper ---either lined or blank, holes or not, but **do not hand in frayed torn edges**.
2. Place your name, course, and due date in the upper right corner of the top page. You may use a cover page for this if you wish.
3. Start the first page leaving a one inch margin as a location for general instructor comments and/or grade.
4. **Staple** multiple pages together in the upper left hand corner (one staple only). Make sure there is sufficient clearance on each page so that your work is not covered by the staple.
5. Each problem should be written on a separate page, and always **use the front side of the paper only**. Instructors should let you know if they will make exceptions to the one problem/one page for very short problems.
6. A clear statement of the problem must be included along with what you are given and what you are attempting to find or determine.
7. Complete your work in a top down order below your problem statement.
8. You should understand, explain, justify the major steps you take. This does not mean show algebraic scratch work like multiplying both sides of the equation by 2 and explaining it. You should be able to recognize the key components of the problem solution and make comments on such steps.
9. Leave room for instructor comments, do not clutter your work.
10. Write large enough and darkly enough.
11. Most of the time your work will be completed on scratch paper after many attempts and you will need to create a copy/document for handing in. For multiproblem assignments (5 to 10 problems) it is expected that hw is started well before the due date and that within a day or two of "due" you have all the problems solved and will need to write up your neat copy of solutions only.
12. Late work is not acceptable ---unless you are in a coma, or some other similar true emergency. Late work may be severely penalized. You are better off demonstrating your completion of an assignment by handing in your time managed mostly complete sloppy copy on time----than handing in late work.

Additional Colbert comments on HW

You should draw any supporting figure (PART OF GRADING), and make careful and neat use of notation (PART OF GRADING). Notation errors are errors. In my own solutions I may verbally indicate what I have done in specific algebra steps, but leave the algebra for scratch paper—for example "take derivatives and use chain rule".

You should give sufficient description to a problem so that ANY reader (other physics students) would understand the problem, the setup, and the solutions ---ie---include supporting ENGLISH STATEMENTS (PART OF GRADING). I feel free to have any other student present another student's problem solution (quickly and concisely)---it is the author who is graded, not the presenter.

We may at times make graphs or make figures? Tools such as Mathematica, Maple, Origin, Excel will be expected.If I request this as an add on to a problem, then the problem will not receive any credit unless you include your graph. (PART OF GRADING).

Copying from others will not be tolerated. Allowing someone to copy your work will not be tolerated. You are not to copy from David Griffiths (particularly his errors). You should not ever make, or be in possession of electronic copies (pictures included) of anyone else's work.

NEATNESS-----I must be able to read your work. So Part of neatness means sufficient size, also sufficient contrast (be able to push your pencil down on the paper hard enough to make a mark). Your work will be stapled. If your staple goes through parts of your own work, then I cannot read your work.

English comments are expected during many components of problems. Setup, conclusion, or other explanatory steps should be written out.

Standard Ratio forms must be used in writing. Expressions may have exactly one numerator and exactly one denominator. These should be separated by a horizontal bar. Do not make use of a diagonal slash to cram your work into a single line. Allow your work to span multiple lines if needed. If an equation is too long for a single line, use brackets or other symbolic notation as needed. For example do not write $[4\pi\epsilon_o]^{-1}$ **but instead write** $\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_o}$ **this is required for readability and is not open for discussion.**

Create your own problem-(CYOP)--Every assignment has CYOP which is your own creation. You must have a problem statement along with a solution to the problem, and you should have a classmate look at your problem at least a day ahead of the due date. These should be mid-level difficulty problems. Problems which appear as last minute plug'n'chug/grind problems will be graded accordingly. Problems with incorrect solutions are not acceptable (minor algebra errors are treated differently than major conceptual goofs).

